Rahul smiled. He has one of the most genuinely affectionate smiles I have come across.

The dias where he was supposed to give his speech began looming ahead of us. I was out of words and slowly inched my way backwards and mingled with the crowd walking behind Rahul. That was the last conversation Rahul had for the day before he gave his evening speech from the dias. I had got a good twenty minutes of walking with him, along with a conversation.

Was this the same man that the media kept caricaturing as ‘Pappu’? Who supposedly watched Pogo and Cartoon Network? Was this the reluctant politician the BJP made him out to be? The entitled prince who was served everything on a golden platter? Was this really the same man who had been constantly maligned over the past decade or so?

Contrary to what people have been made to believe, the person I met was articulate, well read, polished and genuine. His smile was filled with warmth and his eyes oozed empathy.

Rahul came across as easygoing, a great conversationalist, someone you could talk to, someone who you know will listen to what you have to say instead of launching into a monologue to impose his ideas on you. I am not sure if such people win elections. He did not come across as someone cunning, ruthless, mean and crafty. I can’t be, and wouldn’t be, around such a person. But Rahul I would hug any time again.

I had gone to the Bharat Jodo Yatra to take part in an event attempting to bring India together. Rahul, by his own admission, was doing this to discover India first-hand. I came back discovering myself anew.

I came back inspired by this charming person, who taught me to put my country ahead of all petty politics, ahead of any leader or party. He taught me to stand up for a cause and not for a particular individual.

I would really like to see Rahul Gandhi succeed. But more than that, I would like India to succeed. An India where unity in diversity thrives, where ‘*sarva dharma samabhaav*’ thrives. Where equality, justice, liberty and fairness are enshrined in its constitutional values. Where we can all live as one family irrespective of our differences. Where we can build such